

value superclasses. Within the cryptoassets class there are the subclasses of cryptocurrencies, cryptocommodities, and cryptotokens.

ETFs AND MUTUAL FUNDS ARE WRAPPERS, NOT ASSET CLASSES

It should be noted that when we talk about asset classes we are not doing so in the context of the investment vehicle that may “house” the underlying asset, whether that vehicle is a mutual fund, ETF, or separately managed account. With the growth of financial engineering and securitization of nearly every asset—and especially with the growing popularity of ETFs—one may find every type of asset at some point housed within an ETF. For example, ETFs for bitcoin and ether are already in the filing process with the SEC. For the purpose of our definition of asset classes, we are distinguishing the asset class from the form within which they are traded.

Delineating the separation between asset classes is no easy task. Greer gives us one solid point to distinguish assets, the economic similarities, but then leaves the rest to “characteristics that make them distinct.” We’ve reviewed the academic literature further in order to crystallize the difference between asset classes. Much of the thinking in this chapter grew out of a collaboration between ARK Invest and Coinbase through late 2015 and into 2016 when the two firms first made